

Syllabus

ECON 365W, Topics in Economic History
Spring 2026
Asynchronous

Axel Weber
aweber20@gmu.edu

Office Hours by Appointment (online or in-person)
Usually I am free Monday-Wednesday before 11am.

COURSE OBJECTIVES AND LEARNING OUTCOMES:

In this class we will explore the political economy of war in American history. We will begin the course by revisiting the institution of slavery. Was the civil war inevitable? Was it the only way to end slavery? Then we will move on to the Great War, the Great Depression, and World War II. What are the civil and economic consequences of war? What were the Founding Father's worries with war? Are their fears confirmed by the experience with the American Empire, or disproved?

This course is a writing intensive course and therefore a paper is required by the end of the semester.

MASON CORE:

This class is a Mason Core [course](#) and counts towards partial fulfillment of the “[Exploration requirement](#)” of Mason Core as a “Social and Behavioral Science” class. The [Learning Outcomes](#) for Social and Behavioral Science courses are as follows.

Upon completing a Social and Behavioral course, students will be able to:

1. Explain how individuals, groups, or institutions are influenced by contextual factors.
2. Demonstrate awareness of changes in social and cultural constructs.
3. Use appropriate methods and resources to apply social and behavioral science concepts, terminology, principles, and theories in the analysis of significant human issues, past or present.

WRITING INTENSIVE

Upon completing a Writing Intensive Course, students will be able to:

1. Use informal or formal writing in ways that deepen their awareness of the field of study and its subject matter (Writing to Learn).
2. Compose one or more written genres specific to the field of study in order to communicate key ideas tailored to specific audiences and purposes; genres may be academic, public, or professional (Writing to Communicate).

3. Draft and revise written works based on feedback they receive from instructors and peers, using strategies appropriate to the genre, audience, and purpose (Writing as a Process).

COURSE MATERIALS:

The course materials consist of online asynchronous class lectures, readings from the required books, and miscellaneous papers I will provide.

Required books:

- *Emancipating Slaves, Enslaving Free Men: A History of the American Civil War*, by Jeffry R. Hummel, second edition
- *The Governmental Habit Redux: Economic Controls from Colonial Times to the Present*, by Jonathan Hughes
- *Crisis and Leviathan: Critical Episodes in the Growth of American Government*, by Robert Higgs
- *In Search of Monsters to Destroy: The Folly of American Empire and the Paths to Peace*, by Christopher Coyne
- *Tyranny Comes Home: The Domestic Fate of U.S. Militarism*, by Christopher Coyne
- *Manufacturing Militarism: U.S. Government Propaganda in the War on Terror*, by Christopher Coyne

TENTATIVE SCHEDULE

(Subject to change at my discretion – all changes will be announced online)

Week 1: Review of Economics

Sunday:

- [Economics as an Historical Science](#) by McCloskey,
- [Logic is a harsh mistress: welfare economics for economists](#) by Peter Leeson,
- [The Transitional Gains Trap](#) by Gordon Tullock,
- [Toward a Theory of Property Rights](#) by Harold Demsetz,
- [Institutional Stickiness and the New Development Economics](#) by Peter Boettke, Christopher Coyne, and Peter Leeson

Optional ***Highly Recommended*** reading for a refresher on the economic way of thinking:
[Economics as a Way of Thinking](#), by Paul Heyne

Week 2

Wednesday:

- [The Use of Knowledge in Society](#) by F. A. Hayek,
- [Protection or Free Trade](#) by Henry George *pages 37-48*
- [The Political Economy of Crisis Opportunism](#) by Robert Higgs (download the pdf from the link)

Sunday:

- *The Governmental Habit Redux*, pages 12-53

Week 3

Wednesday:

- *The Governmental Habit Redux*, pages 54-91

Sunday:

- *The Governmental Habit Redux*, pages 92-135

Week 4

Wednesday:

- *The Governmental Habit Redux*, pages 182-84, 229-231 (starting on the last new paragraph of 229)
- [Can economics rank slavery against free labor in terms of efficiency?](#) By Lawrence White
- [Democracy in America](#), by Alexis de Tocqueville (selection)
- *Emancipating Slaves, Enslaving Free Men*, introduction, preface, and prologue

Sunday:

- *Emancipating Slaves, Enslaving Free Men*, chapters 2 and 5 (including bibliographical essay, you don't need to know or read sources, just read the commentary)

Week 5

Wednesday:

- *Emancipating Slaves, Enslaving Free Men*, chapters 6, 8, and 9

Sunday:

- *Emancipating Slaves, Enslaving Free Men*, chapters 10, 11, and sections 1-2 of chapter 12

Week 6

Wednesday:

- *Emancipating Slaves, Enslaving Free Men*, chapter 13 and epilogue

Sunday:

- *Crisis and Leviathan*, chapter 5

Week 7

Wednesday:

- *Crisis and Leviathan*, chapters 6-7

Sunday:

- *Crisis and Leviathan*, chapter 8

Week 8

Wednesday:

- *Crisis and Leviathan*, chapter 9

Sunday:

- [*Delusions of Power*](#), chapter 10-11
- *Crisis and Leviathan*, chapters 10-11

Week 9

Wednesday:

- *In Search of Monsters to Destroy*, read the quote by John Quincy Adams on the page before the table of contents, preface, prologue, and chapters 1-2

Sunday:

- *In Search of Monsters to Destroy*, chapters 3-4

Week 10

Wednesday:

- *In Search of Monsters to Destroy*, chapters 5-6

Sunday:

- *In Search of Monsters to Destroy*, chapter 7-epilogue
- *Tyranny Comes Home*, quotes on the page before acknowledgements, preface

Week 11

Wednesday:

- *Tyranny Comes Home*, chapters 1-2

Sunday:

- *Tyranny Comes Home*, chapters 3-4

Week 12

Wednesday:

- *Tyranny Comes Home*, chapters 5-6

Sunday:

- *Tyranny Comes Home*, chapter 7 and conclusion

Week 13

Wednesday:

- *Manufacturing Militarism*, preface, chapters 1-2

Sunday:

- *Manufacturing Militarism*, chapters 3-4

Week 14

Wednesday:

- *Manufacturing Militarism*, chapters 5-6

Sunday:

- *Manufacturing Militarism*, chapter 7 and conclusion

COURSE STRUCTURE & GRADING:

Lectures will be posted periodically to discuss the books and readings. Students are expected to have completed the necessary readings. Take notes while watching the lectures—otherwise you will zone out. Email me any questions you have regarding the content or information.

Your final grade is based on written reading checks, an in-person midterm and final, and a term paper.

1. Reading checks: 25%
2. Midterm: 20%
3. Term paper: 25%
4. Final exam: 30%

Reading checks:

The required readings should take approximately 10 pages a day (including weekends; excluding spring break). Motivation, however, usually kicks in right before assignments are due. To make the readings more digestible and enjoyable I am assigning two weekly reading checks, due every Wednesday and Sunday. Therefore, the scramble to read shouldn't be more than 30-50 pages for any given day.

The reading checks will be 1 free response question. The reading checks are around 10-15 minutes long. The questions are text specific to ensure careful reading. Do not use AI to answer the questions. Using AI is an automatic failure.

Each reading check is graded on a 0-4 point scale. Your answers should be 100-250 words long.

Your two lowest reading checks will be dropped.

Midterm:

I will announce what material the midterm will cover. Content covered in the lectures and readings are fair game. The format will be short and long answer written responses.

If you miss the midterm, I will increase the value of your final exam to 50% of your course grade.

Final exam:

The final exam's date and time are set by the University and are non-negotiable. The final exam is comprehensive and will include *all* material covered throughout the semester. The exam format will be short and long answer written responses.

Exam content will include the material covered in class and in the assigned readings. This means that anything that I cover in lectures is subject to being on the exams, even if it is not in the assigned readings.

Students who have geographic or other issues with coming to class in-person should reach out to me in advance (at least one week) to discuss the possibility of an oral exam.

Term paper:

This course includes a semester-long research paper. The purpose of the paper is to analyze a question in economic history using the tools and ideas learned in the readings and lectures. The paper must make an argument and advance a causal or mechanism-based explanation.

While this course focuses on the political economy of war and crisis, your paper does not have to. Any topic in economic history is acceptable, provided it involves institutions, policy, or political-economic incentives and is approved by me.

The final paper must be at least 3,500 words (about 12–14 double-spaced pages), not including references.

The paper is broken into four required components:

Paper Proposal (1%) — Due Sunday by 11:59pm, Week 6 — (I will send a reminder in advance)

The proposal should be about 300–500 words. It should clearly state:

- Your research question
- The historical case or period you will examine
- Your tentative argument or mechanism (even if provisional)
- A short list of initial sources (at least 3)

Sources should be peer reviewed academic papers. JSTOR, Google Scholar, and the GMU library are extremely useful for accessing papers. (I recommend starting with Google Scholar—papers that aren't open access are often available through the GMU library)

I will let you know if your proposal could work, or if it is too broad, vague, or not workable.

Outline + Annotated Bibliography (1%) — Due Sunday, Week 8

This should include:

- A section-by-section outline of the paper (headings of each section plus 1-3 sentence description)
- An annotated bibliography of at least 6 sources, with 1–2 sentences explaining what each source contributes to your paper. Sources must be peer reviewed papers or books/chapters written by academics.

This assignment is meant to ensure that you have a real structure and real sources before you start writing seriously. Your outline must be approved before you can move on to the draft.

Full Draft (5%) — Due Sunday, Week 10

The draft must be a substantially complete paper of at least 2,000 words. It should have a clear argument, structure, and evidence. The references should be included on a separate page at the bottom without the annotations.

I will provide feedback on argument, structure, and content. I will not line-edit. Recall that using AI is an automatic failure.

Final Paper (18%) — Due Sunday, Last Week of Class

The final paper should be at least 3,500 words (12–14 double-spaced pages), not including references. It should reflect a serious revision of the draft based on feedback. It should cite at least 8 academic sources.

You are being graded on:

- Clarity of the question and argument
- Quality of the economic explanation
- Use of evidence and sources
- Organization and clarity of writing

If at any point in the semester you decide to change the topic of your paper, you may do so, but you must complete all prior steps. e.g., if you change your paper topic after the outline, you will need to submit a new paper proposal, wait for approval, and then submit a new outline.

AI and authorship

You may use tools for brainstorming or proofreading, but the argument, structure, and content of the paper must be your own. Work that is clearly not your own will receive a zero.

Use the standard Times New Roman, size 12 font, double-spaced.

GRADING SCALE:

Final grades will be assigned as follows:

A+ 98-100; A 92-97; A- 90-91; B+ 88-89; B 82-87; B- 80-81; C+ 78-79; C 72-77; C- 70-71; D 60-69; F Below 60

I do round up (for example, if your final weighted-average grade is 71.5 you have earned a C for the course), but I do not raise grades upon request (for example, if your final weighted-average grade is 87 you have earned a B for the course, not a B+).

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CLASS SUCCESS:

Asynchronous classes are difficult. To succeed in this class, I recommend taking short notes that condense what you have learned from each page or section as you read. Doing so will help you retain the information and study for the exams. As you read, write down any questions or confusions you have. If the writing is difficult to understand, use an AI like ChatGPT to help you. If the questions or confusions you have are about the economics or history, please schedule a time to meet with me via Zoom.

Don't be afraid to schedule office hours! I'm always happy to meet if you want to have a relaxed conversation about economics, related to the class or otherwise, or if you want to ask for advice in general.

SPECIAL ACCOMMODATIONS:

If you require any special accommodations, please reach out to me so that we can work together to make sure that you have what you need to succeed in this course. Please bring [appropriate paperwork](#) from the University.

AI POLICY

I highly recommend using AI (such as ChatGPT) to answer any questions or confusions you may have before bringing them to me. AI is a great tool that can supplement your learning—but it *cannot* replace it. Use AI to help explain difficult concepts, but do not use it to skip the readings. Keep in mind that AI is often wrong and is just a predictive algorithm of what letter is the best next option. You will know that you understand a concept when you can explain it to someone else (in real life or by writing a paragraph to an imaginary curious mind). AI can help you get to become proficient, but only if you don't use it as a crutch.

Use of AI for generative writing is an automatic failure.

ACADEMIC DISHONESTY:

It is expected that students adhere to the George Mason University Academic Standards as it relates to integrity regarding coursework and grades. The Academic Standards reads as follows: “As members of the George Mason University community, we are committed to fostering an environment of trust, respect, and scholarly excellence. Our academic standards are the foundation of this commitment, guiding our behavior and interactions within this academic community. The practices for implementing these standards adapt to modern practices, disciplinary contexts, and technological advancements. Our standards are embodied in our courses, policies, and scholarship, and are upheld in the following principles:

- **Honesty:** Providing accurate information in all academic endeavors, including communications, assignments, and examinations.
- **Acknowledgement:** Giving proper credit for all contributions to one's work. This involves the use of accurate citations and references for any ideas, words, or materials created by others in the style appropriate to the discipline. It also includes acknowledging shared authorship in group projects, co-authored pieces, and project reports.
- **Uniqueness of Work:** Ensuring that all submitted work is the result of one's own effort and is original, including free from self-plagiarism. This principle extends to written assignments, code, presentations, exams, and all other forms of academic work.

Violations of these standards—including but not limited to plagiarism, fabrication, and cheating—are taken seriously and will be addressed in accordance with university policies. The process for reporting, investigating, and adjudicating violations is outlined in the university's procedures. Consequences of violations may include academic sanctions, disciplinary actions, and other measures necessary to uphold the integrity of our academic community.

The principles outlined in these academic standards reflect our collective commitment to upholding the highest standards of honesty, acknowledgement, and uniqueness of work. By adhering to these principles, we ensure the continued excellence and integrity of George Mason University's academic community." More information can be found [here](#).

Further information on Mason Course Policies are available [here](#).